

08 — The Press, the People, the Unions

The tactical hinge between design and execution. Trade unions may appear to carry a brake weight, but they do so only in the third order. Their membership base is the people — and the people are moved by the press. He who possesses the press, possesses the people; he who possesses the people, ultimately steers the unions. The Pareto reversal mechanism that sets Edition 6 and Nova Democratia in motion without changing a single law.

The Pareto Reversal

In the heatmap of Edition 6, Episode 9, the trade unions appear with a significant brake weight from Phase 2 through Phase 5 — precisely the phases in which Nova Democratia would be implemented. The conventional conclusion is: negotiate with the unions, conclude agreements, grant concessions. It is a contest that the design cannot win, because conservation is the very *raison d'être* of the union. A trade union that consents to fundamental administrative restructuring loses its function and thereby its income — no organisation voluntarily signs off on its own diminution. Those who walk this path are met with twenty years of negotiation and no restructuring.

But there is a second path, and it lies ready for the taking within the very structure of the union itself. A trade union exists by the grace of its members. Members are employees. Employees are citizens. Citizens are moved by what they read, hear, and see daily. He who possesses the press, possesses the attention of the citizen; he who convinces the citizen that he is being disadvantaged by his own union, will see the union change course within one to two years — or lose members. No union survives a prolonged period of membership drain. It is the only lever with which a conservative organisation can correct itself without its leadership desiring to do so. This is not cynicism. It is how democracy functions technically as soon as an organisation positions itself between the citizen and the decision: the citizen remains sovereign, and if the organisation resists, the citizen can bypass the organisation.

What the Press Does in Practice

The press possesses three levers, not one. The first lever: agenda-setting. Which subjects receive weekly attention, and which fade from view. When Giant Juncao, BiCRS, and plastic storage in open-cast mines appear for four weeks in *de Volkskrant*, *NRC*, *FAZ*, and *Le Monde* — not as opinion pieces but as reportage — public opinion tilts within two months. When those same subjects remain undiscussed for three years (as is currently the case), the idea does not exist. Through selection, the press determines what does and does not exist in the public memory.

The second lever: framing. Is waste incineration presented as a “sustainable energy supply” or as “power generation with the highest hidden costs in Europe”? Is Giant Juncao presented as a “Chinese experiment in Africa” or as a “European opportunity for carbon sovereignty”? Both framings are factually defensible; only the second leads to movement. The press chooses which framing it employs — and that choice determines whether the public stands with or against the design. He who provides the framing wins the minds of the citizens within one year, and with them, the votes at the general meetings of the unions.

The third lever: personal recognition. When the Dutch FNV chairman is depicted as the brake weight holding back the Rotterdam pilot, and the Bondsraad champion as the pragmatic executor ensuring employment, every ordinary FNV-Bond-Vervoer member engages in a conversation on his shop floor about who is actually standing up for his job. That conversation is what corrects the union — not the law, not collective bargaining, nor the political debate in The Hague. The conversation at the coffee machine of a dockworker, nourished by ten articles in his daily paper, is what causes a union to alter its course within two years.

Why This is Not Manipulation

A possible objection: this sounds like the manipulation of public opinion through selective reporting. It is the opposite. In the current situation, the press renders Giant Juncao, BiCRS, and plastic storage in open-cast mines undiscussable by systematically failing to name them. That, too, is a choice — a choice that serves the interests of the existing industry (waste incineration, recycling, fossil fuels) without them being defended aloud. What is proposed here is not new manipulation, but the removal of the existing kind. Give the citizen access to the first-order facts — the productivity of Juncao, the CO₂ emissions of waste incineration plants, the geological stability of plastic in open-cast mines — and let him conclude for himself. He will correct his union, or he will leave it. In either case, the brake weight is dissolved.

The Mechanism Step by Step

- Step 1: A European economic Bondsraad publishes six pages monthly of measured facts regarding the two levers — productivity, emissions, storage stability, geographical advantage of competitors — in a form and language that can be adopted by the broad press.
- Step 2: Three to five serious European newspapers take the figures seriously and publish weekly reports, not opinion pieces.
- Step 3: Citizens read about Giant Juncao and plastic storage in open-cast mines. Within three months, they know there is an alternative to waste incineration and that their existing regulations are blocking these alternatives.
- Step 4: General meetings of trade unions receive agenda items concerning the position of their union regarding the two levers. Initially marginal, after a year, standard.
- Step 5: Trade unions that persist in blockage lose members — especially younger members who see the employment opportunities in new industries. Trade unions that move with the tide, grow.
- Step 6: Within two to three years, the blockage effect of the unions has disappeared, not through legislation but through self-correction.

The Role of the Knowledge Layer

Episode 11 of Edition 6 introduced the knowledge layer as an ally — universities, planning bureaus, advisory councils, research institutes. Here it comes into action as the supplier of the facts that the press disseminates. When TNO, Fraunhofer, ETH Zürich, and the CPB publish joint reports on the productivity of Giant Juncao, the CO₂ balance of plastic storage in open-cast mines, and the actual emissions per kWh of waste incineration plants, the press receives material that no editor can ignore. The knowledge layer provides the first-order measurement; the press provides the distribution; the citizen provides the vote; the union corrects itself.

The Positive Reversal — When the Pie Grows

What has been described above is the pressure mechanism: providing facts, choosing framing, establishing personal recognition, and the unions correct themselves or lose members. It works, but it works against resistance. There is a second, more powerful mechanism elaborated in Episode 9: when the two levers operate on an industrial scale, there is more prosperity to be distributed for everyone — tens of billions of euros in new industrial turnover for Europe, hundreds of billions in direct investments for South America and Africa, structural savings on climate damage and sanctions. In a growing pie, no one has to give anything up. The unions gain more to negotiate, not less; municipalities receive more tax revenue; employees receive higher wages and better pensions. The constitutional educational function of the NPO, ARD/ZDF, BBC, and Radio France is the channel through which this shared growth in prosperity can be explained to the population — not as propaganda, but as the execution of an already existing media mandate. Episode 9 works this out in full.

Who Does Not Wish to See This

This mechanism is not unknown. Everyone in European administration knows it. But it is avoided for the same reason the two levers are avoided: it would disrupt existing relations. The recycling industry loses subsidies. Waste incinerators lose permits. Trade unions lose identity. Political parties lose their stances. He who sets a chain of this type of self-correction in motion harvests an unrecognisable landscape within five years. That is precisely the goal. The restructuring proposed by Nova Democratia requires that the European landscape becomes unrecognisable — not only institutionally, but industrially, syndically, and in terms of the media. The press is not a weapon in this, but the channel through which factual reality is able to compel third-order procedures.

This episode is currently being further developed with a concrete press strategy per pilot, a list of European newspapers and editors, and the blueprint for the first twelve publications.